

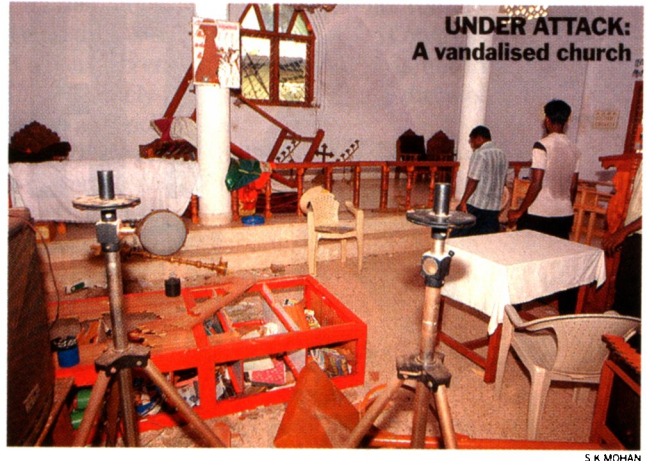
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Shock of the New



There comes a time in politics when the familiar is redeemed by the unknown. In the global blockbuster that is the American presidential election, it has been a hero-driven script so far. Barack Hussein Obama with his exotic back story, stretching from Kansas to Kenya, is an American hero who has already made the Democratic ticket a historic event. Mythified by the liberal media as an uber-cool, postmodern messiah in these darkest of times and celebrated by the dissenting class from the creamy echelons of American society as a prophet with a multicultural aura, the first-time senator from Illinois has already become a movement. In the age of George W. Bush and Iraq, the man with a funny name and a golden tongue is an irresistible fashion statement. He said change—one of those abiding clichés in politics—and the word suddenly acquired a magnetic pull. And John McCain, the war-scarred Republican candidate with an equally engrossing back story, looked more antique. For a while, it was as though defying the Obama mystique was a crime against humanity. The race was entirely his—to win or lose.

No longer. Enter Sarah Palin, frontier woman as warrior queen, as McCain's running mate and 'change' ceases to be the monopoly of Obamaniacs. Never mind the governor of Alaska continues to be caricatured by the Beltway Brahmins as a moose-hunting, gun-toting usurper whose world view does not extend beyond Wasilla. But the lipstick revolution of the hockey mom has energised a Republican Party wallowing in defeatism—and McCain suddenly looks less antique, a candidate who can utter the word 'change' without sounding ironic. Look beyond the caricaturing and media inquisition and we can't miss one big truth: Palin has done to the GOP what Obama has done to the Democratic Party. If the post-Reagan Conservatism badly needed a liberator, it was not McCain. And if the post-Clinton Democratic Party needed a moderniser, it was not Hillary. Obama and Palin, both in their 40s and separated by style and slogan, are nevertheless united by the generational spirit of change. They have changed the syntax of their political heritage, like David Cameron has rewritten conservatism in the post-Thatcher Britain. They are leaders with a difference, and their moment is not far away. Wish the other great democracy had an equally inspiring leadership story to offer. Sadly, the new in India is yet to challenge the order of the grey on either side of the political divide.



Peace Crucified

BANGALORE After Kandhamal, it is now Karnataka. Even as the BJP's high-profile national executive meet was winding up in the state capital on September 14, churches and prayer halls in three of its districts—Mangalore, Udupi and Chikmagalur—were being attacked by alleged saffron groups. Over 18 churches have been vandalised in the three districts by alleged Bajrang Dal activists. The incidents have snowballed into a violent turn of events. On September 15, the police resorted to lathicharge and fired teargas

shells to control mobs that clashed with each other and pelted stones over religious differences in Mangalore. Despite Section 144 of the IPC being imposed in the city, sporadic incidents of violence continued.

Saffron groups allege that the churches in the area were resorting to malicious campaigning against Hindu gods in a bid at conversion. "The state will not tolerate acts of deriding other religions," said Chief Minister B.S. Yeddyurappa, taking a tough stand on conversions.

by Swagata Sen

Fare for All

BANGALORE The Bangalore Metropolitan Transport Corporation (BMT) implemented one of its wildest schemes recently when it slashed the fares of its local Volvo buses to Re 1 for four days to give the poor man a chance to ride in airconditioned comfort. Now this was not only a promotional gimmick for the Volvo service, but also a supposed unofficial celebration of 100 days of BJP rule in the state. The

news spread, and what the BMT had not bargained for were the crowds that were falling out of the doors, while the regular Volvo commuters became a disgruntled lot. The regular fares—between Rs 10 and Rs 80—are back now, but some regular commuters have sworn off the bus forever. The BMT has incurred losses of a few lakh rupees per day. Officially, however, they called the move a resounding success.

by Swagata Sen